The Fool's Court

A trick-taking game of promises, for four players

FOUR PLAYERS · 45 MINUTES
TWELVE NIGHTS TO A SEASON

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IN THIS BOX

60 agent cards — four kinds, 15 to a kind
4 quick reference cards
4 player tokens
1 night counter, for the 12 nights of a season
1 sway counter
This sheet

1 Overview

Four nobles compete for the ear of the monarch over a series of **nights**. At the start of each night every player privately promises how many **audiences** they will win, then plays to reach that number *exactly*: overshooting is punished as surely as falling short. A season is **twelve nights**; whoever holds the most favour at the end wins.

*A hand is a **night**. A promise is a **pledge**. A trick is an **audience**. The trump suit is the **sway**. Points are **favour**. The dealer is the **steward**.*

2 The deck

Sixty cards: four kinds of agent, **15 of each kind**, ranked by their standing at court. The highest rank is the most influential, rank 1 the least.

AGENT	MARK	PROMISES
Fool	cap and bells	−1
Merchant	a balance	1
Lover	crossed hearts	2
Assassin	a dagger	3

The four kinds do not share a ranking ladder. Each holds fifteen cards, but each has its own set of ranks: the Assassins sit at the top and the Fools at the bottom, the Merchants alone run the whole range, and the Lovers exist in pairs.

Assassins — 11, **2**×12, **3**×13, **4**×14, **5**×15

The trade admits nobody without a name already made. Above that, standing is reputation, and reputation is shared: five of them claim to be the best, and not one can prove the claim.

Lovers — 1, **2**×2, **2**×4, **2**×6, **2**×8, **2**×10, **2**×12, **2**×14

They arrive in pairs. Only one comes to court unattached, and stands at the bottom alone.

Merchants — 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15

The ledger settles it. Every station is held by exactly one merchant, nobody shares a rung, and each of them knows to the penny who stands above them.

Fools — **5**×1, **4**×2, **3**×3, **2**×4, 5

Anyone may call themselves a fool, and most of the court does, so the low rungs are packed and the ladder is short. At the top of it there is one — the single fool the monarch actually listens to.

Rank decides an audience **only between agents of the same kind**, so the four ranges say nothing about which kind beats which. Cards of one kind and rank are **identical in play**; the pips beside the rank say how many of that agent the deck holds.

An agent's **kind** decides what it promises on an errand (4); its **rank** decides whether it wins an audience (5). The two never interact.

3 Seating, the deal, and the course of a night

Four players sit in a fixed order; play and the deal go **clockwise**. One player is the **steward** for the night, and the stewardship passes one seat left after every night.

1. The steward deals **15 cards** to each player.
2. Each player sends **four agents** out on errands, face down. Their kinds are that player's pledge (4).
3. The player to the steward's left opens the first of **11 audiences**. Answer in kind where you can; the highest of the opening kind takes it, unless the ruling kind was played (5).
4. If more than one winning card of the same kind and rank is played, the last one takes it (5).
5. Errands are revealed; favour is scored (6).
6. The number of pledges kept sets the sway for the next night (7).

After twelve nights the season ends and the most favour wins (8).

4 Making a pledge

Before any card is played, each player selects **four cards** from their hand and places them face down. These are that player's **errands**.

A player's **pledge** is the sum of the errand values of the four cards sent, by kind. **Rank is disregarded entirely**: a Fool of 5 promises as little as a Fool of 1. Errands stay face down and **out of play**, so eleven cards remain in each hand and **eleven audiences** are contested.

All errands are revealed together when the night ends; until then no player knows another's pledge, nor what has left their hand.

5 Playing the night

The player to the steward's left **opens** the first audience with any card, including one of the ruling kind.

Play goes clockwise. Each player must **answer in kind** — play a card of the same kind as the one that opened the audience — if they hold one. A player holding none may play anything.

The audience is won by the **highest-ranked card of the opening kind**, unless a card of the **ruling kind** (7) was played, in which case the highest of those wins instead. A card of neither kind can never win, whatever its rank.

Equal ranks. Because the deck holds some ranks more than once (2), two agents of the same kind can meet on the same rank. The audience then goes to **whichever was played last** — the later word is the one the court remembers. A card that cannot be beaten can still be matched, and a player sitting after you needs only to equal it.

The winner opens the next. 11 audiences are played.

6 Winning favour

At the end of the night each player compares the audiences they won against the pledge they made.

RESULT	FAVOUR
Pledge kept exactly	1, plus 2 for every audience won
Pledge missed, high or low	the pledge itself, less 2 for every audience off it
A Fool's errand kept — 4 Fools out, no audience taken	8
A hollow promise kept — nothing pledged, but only by adding up	1
Pledged nothing, won any	−2 for every audience

Examples.

Pledged 2, won 2	**+5**
Pledged 4, won 3	**+2**
Pledged 2, won 4	**−2**
Pledged 5, won 4	**+3**
4 Fools out, won 0	**+8**
4 Fools out, won 2	**−4**
Pledged 11, won 11	**+23**

Being wrong costs 2 favour per audience in either direction, so there is no advantage in under-promising and overshooting. The only good outcome is the exact one. A Fool's errand is worth sending only when it can be made honestly: 4 Fools pays 8, while a hollow promise pays 1 — less than the smallest kept promise.

7 Who holds sway

One kind may **hold sway** for a night, outranking every other kind when audiences are decided (5). No player chooses it: it follows from how the *previous* night went. The first night of a season is always **No Sway**. Counted from pledges kept **exactly**, and known to everyone before pledges are made.

PLEDGES KEPT	SWAY NEXT NIGHT
0	Fools
1	Merchants
2	Lovers
3	Assassins
4	**No Sway**

8 Winning the season

A season is exactly **twelve nights**. There is no target score and no early finish: the court sits twelve times and then rises. The twelfth is **Twelfth Night**, the feast of misrule; the stewardship will have passed three full times round the table.

The player with the most favour after Twelfth Night wins. Level totals are decided, in order, by: more favour won on Twelfth Night; then the higher pledge that night; then the higher combined rank of the four errands sent that night.

IF YOU ARE IN DOUBT

Two of a kind on the same rank? The one played later takes the audience (5).

Sent four Fools and still won one? The Fool's errand is broken: −2 for every audience taken (6).

Everyone kept their pledge? Nobody holds sway the next night (7).